

THE INDIAN THRIFT & RESALE PLAYBOOK

Buy pre-loved for less.
Sell your wardrobe for cash.
Build a reselling side income.

70.73L t

textile waste / year

USD 9.1B

resale market by 2032

+850%

thrift searches

30 pp

complete system

A complete, source-verified guide for India's fastest-growing circular-fashion market

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About this playbook

This is a practical, source-verified system for buying pre-loved fashion for less, selling the clothes you no longer wear, and turning resale into a small side income — written for India in 2026. Every number, rate, rule and platform detail in this book was checked against an official or primary source in October 2026, and the source is named wherever a figure appears.

It is built for three kinds of reader: the shopper who wants good clothes without paying retail; the person with a full cupboard and no idea what it is worth; and the beginner who wants a real, low-investment way to earn from home. You can read it cover to cover, or jump to the chapter you need — the buyer's playbook (Chapter 3), the seller's system (Chapters 6-10) and the money model (Chapter 12) each stand on their own.

How to use it

- **If you want to buy:** start with Chapter 3 (finding your size and condition) and Chapter 6 (spotting fakes) before you send a single rupee.
- **If you want to sell:** Chapter 8 (closet audit), Chapter 10 (pricing) and Chapter 12 (your Instagram store) take you from cupboard to cash.
- **If you want to earn:** Chapters 16-17 give you the reselling model, the margin maths and a 90-day plan.
- **If you want to stay clean:** Chapters 18-19 cover GST, income tax and the consumer rules that apply to online sellers.

A note on honesty

This guide is not affiliated with any brand, marketplace or platform, and no platform paid to be included. Where a fee, rate or rule could change — courier charges, GST rules, platform commissions — treat the figure here as a verified starting point and confirm it on the official site before you rely on it for a large transaction.

Disclaimer

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Introduction: why India fell in love with thrift

Something shifted in Indian wardrobes between 2024 and 2026. Second-hand clothing stopped being a compromise and became a choice — one that a new generation of shoppers makes on purpose, and one that a growing number of people quietly turn into income. Google's own India team reported in October 2026 that searches for "thrifting" hit an all-time high in the country, with "how to thrift" rising 850% and "thrift store near me" up 600% in a single year. Interest in "circular fashion" jumped 2,500%. This is not a niche anymore.

Two forces meet here. The first is money: resale lets a buyer pay 50-80% less than retail for good clothes, and lets a seller recover cash from a cupboard that was only collecting dust. The second is values: extending the life of a garment by even a few months cuts its water, carbon and waste footprint sharply, at a time when India generates roughly 70.73 lakh tonnes of textile waste every year and more than half of it is post-consumer clothing that households discard.

Here is the gap this playbook fills. Most Indian thrifting still happens through Instagram DMs, WhatsApp groups and unverified sellers — with no listings, no search, no grading and no seller protection. The buyer has no way to check a size or a stitch; the seller has no idea what an item is worth or how to ship it safely. And the moment either side wants to do this seriously, a wall of practical questions appears: Which platform? What do I charge? How do I spot a fake? Do I need GST? What if the payment never arrives?

This book answers all of them, in order, with the rules and numbers verified. By the last page you will be able to buy a pre-loved jacket without fear, sell a full cupboard without losing money to scams, and run a small reselling side income with clean books. Let's begin with the market itself.

The one-sentence version

India's resale market is growing at roughly 13% a year toward USD 9.1 billion by 2032 — and the infrastructure to buy, sell and ship pre-loved fashion finally exists. The winners will be the people who know how to price, authenticate and ship. That is what this book teaches.

Chapter 1 — India's thrift boom, in numbers

Before you sell your first kurta or buy your first vintage saree, it helps to see the size of the room you are walking into. Three sets of official numbers tell the story.

70.73 lakh t

TEXTILE WASTE / YEAR

India's annual textile waste, 58% of it post-consumer (Ministry of Textiles, Mar 2026)

USD 9.1B

RESALE MARKET 2032

India's second-hand apparel market, up from USD 3.0B in 2023

+850%

THRIFT SEARCHES

One-year rise in "how to thrift" searches in India (Google, Oct 2026)

The waste economy is the supply side

In March 2026 the Ministry of Textiles released a national mapping of India's textile waste. It found that India generates approximately 70.73 lakh tonnes of textile waste a year. Of that, 58% comes from post-consumer disposal — clothes households have finished with — and 42% from manufacturing. More than 70% of the total is already recovered into reuse, upcycling or recycling streams, and an informal network of roughly 40-45 lakh people, mostly women, earns a living from collecting and sorting used textiles. The government projects the textile recycling market could reach USD 3.5 billion by 2030 and create about one lakh green jobs.

For you, the practical point is simple: there is an enormous, well-established supply of second-hand clothing in India already moving through informal channels. What has changed is that the front end — the part a buyer sees — has moved onto phones and organised platforms, where curation and trust now command a premium.

The demand side is young, urban and online

Google's India team reported that thrifting reached an all-time high on Search, with the strongest interest in Bengaluru, Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Chennai, Kolkata, Kochi, Dehradun, Guwahati and Jaipur. Jackets were the single most-searched thrift item, followed by tops, shoes, jeans and even furniture. Two styles pulled hardest in opposite directions: "Y2K streetwear" on one side and "vintage sarees" and heritage pieces on the other. Searches for "circular fashion" rose 2,500% and "sustainable fashion" climbed 120%.

The market research agrees on direction. India's second-hand apparel market was valued at about USD 3.0 billion in 2023 and is projected to reach roughly USD 9.1 billion by 2032, a compound growth rate near 13% a year. The drivers named in that research are exactly the ones you will see in your own feed: value-conscious young buyers, mobile-first shopping, and community-driven resale built on Instagram and WhatsApp.

What this means for you

Supply is abundant and demand is rising — but trust is scarce. The seller who grades honestly, shows real photos and ships reliably wins repeat buyers. The buyer who checks before paying avoids the scams that fill this space. Both skills are teachable, and both are in this book.

Chapter 2 — The four ways Indians thrift

There is no single thrift market in India. There are four distinct channels, each with its own prices, risks and best use. Knowing which channel fits which job is half the battle — for buying and for selling.

Channel	How it works	Best for	Main risk
Instagram thrift stores	Seller posts numbered "drops"; buyers claim items in DMs and pay by UPI; items ship in batches.	Curated, vintage and statement pieces at the best prices.	Prepaid-only scams; no platform protection.
Resale apps & marketplaces	Structured listings with photos, condition grades and seller ratings; some offer doorstep pickup.	Clearing a wardrobe fast; buying everyday wear with buyer protection.	Lower prices per piece; commission or per-lot fees.
Offline thrift stores & flea markets	Physical shops and weekly markets in most metros; cash or UPI on the spot.	Trying before buying; bulk buys; the thrill of the hunt.	No returns; you must inspect in person.

Channel	How it works	Best for	Main risk
WhatsApp & Telegram groups	Closed groups and broadcast lists where members post items for sale.	Local, same-city, no-shipping deals.	Almost no verification; trust entirely on the group.

Instagram is where the money is — for buyers and sellers

Instagram is the engine of Indian thrifting because curation adds value that an app cannot. A page with a clear niche — Y2K, oversized streetwear, sarees, kidswear — and honest descriptions can command far more per piece than a bulk lot sold to an app. The format is now standardised: the seller posts a numbered drop as carousels or stories, buyers claim items first-come in DMs, pay by UPI to confirm, and the page ships twice a week. Pages with 5,000-15,000 engaged followers routinely clear 30-80 pieces per drop.

Apps and marketplaces are where the convenience is

A newer generation of Indian resale platforms has removed almost all the friction from selling. Pickup apps such as FreeUp operate across 16,000-plus PIN codes with doorstep pickup, and Tooused covers 700-plus cities with bulk collection. Thrift marketplaces like Rewago, Closeit, Presquo and WishThrift give you a searchable storefront; classifieds such as OLX, Quikr and Facebook Marketplace are free and best for local bulk lots. The trade-off is consistent: apps pay less per piece but do the work; Instagram pays the most but needs your time.

Offline is still where you learn

Metro thrift stores and weekly flea markets remain the cheapest place to buy and the fastest way to understand real prices, because you can feel the fabric, check the stitching and negotiate on the spot. For a new seller, a Saturday at a local flea market tells you more about what sells in your city than a month of scrolling. Use it as your classroom.

The channel rule of thumb

Buy where you can verify, sell where you can be verified. For your first purchase, prefer a channel with buyer protection (an app or a marketplace). For your first sale, prefer the channel that lets you show your face, your reviews and your process (Instagram).

Chapter 3 — The buyer's playbook: size, condition, fit

Most bad thrift buys fail for one of three reasons: the size was wrong, the condition was worse than described, or the seller was a scam. This chapter kills the first two. Chapter 6 kills the third.

Rule one: buy the measurements, never the label

A "size M" from a 2014 fast-fashion label and a "size M" from a premium brand can differ by several centimetres, and clothes shrink, stretch and get altered. Sellers who know their trade publish measurements in centimetres — chest, length, shoulder and waist — and those numbers, not the tag, are what you should trust. If a listing gives only a letter size, ask for measurements before you pay. A seller who will not provide them is telling you something.

Rule two: learn the condition ladder

Reputable resellers grade condition on a simple scale. Insist that the grade is stated, and read it literally.

Grade	What it should mean	Fair price guide (of original retail)
New with tags (NWT)	Unused, original tags still attached.	50-70%
Like new	Worn once or twice; no visible flaws.	40-60%
Good	Worn and washed; minor signs of use, no damage.	25-40%
Fair	Clear wear, fading or a disclosed flaw; still wearable.	10-25%

Rule three: make the seller prove the item exists

Photos can be stolen. A short video call, or a 15-second clip showing the item beside today's newspaper or a handwritten note with your name, is something a scammer using stock photos cannot produce. Ask for it before any prepaid transfer on a high-value piece. Genuine sellers will not mind; the honest ones are competing for your trust against the dishonest ones.

The 30-second pre-purchase checklist

Before you pay for any pre-loved piece: (1) measurements in cm, (2) condition grade, (3) photos of any flaw, (4) tag and wash-label photo, (5) whether shipping is included, and (6) the payment and return terms. If any of the six is missing, ask for it — a good seller will have it ready.

Rule four: know what to ask in the first message

A single, well-built DM saves an hour of back-and-forth. Send the seller all of this at once:

- Exact measurements: chest, length, shoulder, waist (in cm).
- Condition grade, plus photos of any flaw — especially stains, pilling, missing buttons or altered hems.
- Brand tag photo and the wash-care label (this also helps authentication).
- Whether the price includes shipping, and which courier they use.
- Payment method and the return policy in one line.

Sizing is the dispute engine of clothing resale

Measurements kill most disputes before they start. When you sell, put measurements in every caption; when you buy, never pay for a garment whose measurements you have not seen. This single habit prevents more arguments than any return policy.

Chapter 4 — Judging fabric and quality by hand

Price and brand matter, but fabric is what you will feel every time you wear the garment. Learning to read a piece by hand is the skill that stops you overpaying for a shirt that will pill in a month.

Start with the wash-care label

The inner label names the fibre composition and is the fastest quality filter. Natural fibres — cotton, linen, silk, wool, viscose/rayon — behave differently from synthetics, and blends sit in between. A garment whose label has been cut out, or which lists only a vague "polyester blend", is a question mark. Ask for a photo of the label before you buy.

Fibre	Feel and behaviour	What to watch
Cotton	Breathable, holds shape, softens with wash.	Cheap cotton thins and loses shape.
Linen	Cool, textured, creases a lot.	Check for weak, worn spots at stress points.
Silk / wool	Premium drape and warmth.	Moths and pilling; check for tiny holes.
Viscose / rayon	Soft, drapey, inexpensive feel.	Shrinks and pills if low quality.
Polyester / blends	Durable, wrinkle-resistant, cheap.	Traps heat; check for shine and pilling.

The flaw checklist

Inspect every piece against this list before you pay. A disclosed flaw is fine; an undisclosed one is the whole problem.

- **Pilling and bobbling** under the arms and at the cuffs — the first sign of a tired fabric.
- **Colour fade or uneven patches**, especially on dark denims and printed cottons.
- **Stretched or wavy seams** and loose threads at stress points (armholes, waist, crotch).
- **Missing buttons, broken zips, absent belt or dupatta** — factor the repair cost in.
- **Alterations** — a hem taken up twice, or a waist let out, changes the fit and the value.
- **Odours** — musty or smoky smells are hard to remove and often signal damp storage.

Repairs worth doing — and worth avoiding

A ₹50 button replacement can lift a garment from "fair" to "good". But a major lining replacement, a re-dye, or re-stitching a collapsed seam usually costs more than the piece is worth. The rule: repair only when the fix is small, cheap and invisible.

The feel test

Rub the fabric between your fingers, stretch it gently, and hold it to the light. If it pills, shines, or feels thin and papery, it will not survive many more washes — price it as "fair", or leave it.

Chapter 5 — Negotiation and making an offer

Haggling is welcome in some thrift settings and unwelcome in others. Reading the room is part of the skill — and a polite, well-timed offer gets a yes far more often than a lowball.

Where to negotiate — and where not to

Setting	Negotiation?	How to do it
Flea markets & street stalls	Yes, expected	Bundle several items and ask for a round-number total.
Classifieds (OLX, Quikr)	Yes	Make a specific, reasonable offer in your first message.
Instagram drops	Usually fixed	Do not haggle on a priced drop; ask about bundles instead.
Marketplace listings	Sometimes	Use "Make an offer" features where the platform provides them.

How to make an offer that gets a yes

- 1 Lead with intent: "I would like to buy this — would you consider Rs. ___?" A serious buyer is easier to say yes to.
- 2 Justify the number: condition, a small flaw, or buying more than one piece.
- 3 Bundle: "If I take all three, would you do Rs. ___ for the lot?" Sellers love a bigger single sale.
- 4 Be ready to pay immediately. An offer you honour on the spot is worth more than a long negotiation.
- 5 Never be rude about the item. "It is not worth that" ends the conversation; "given the small stain, would you do Rs. ___?" does not.

If you are the seller

Set a floor before you list — the lowest price you will accept — and never go below it in the moment. Build small room into your asking price so a bundle discount still leaves a profit. A buyer who asks for a fair discount on several pieces is your best customer; reward them.

The bundle is the polite discount

Instead of cutting the price of one item, offer "buy two, get 15% off". Both sides win: the buyer feels they negotiated, and your average order value goes up.

Chapter 6 — The authentication chapter: how to spot a fake

The counterfeit market has moved down-market. It is no longer just fake luxury handbags; scammers now target mid-tier brands that younger buyers actually wear. Counterfeits are engineered to pass a one-second glance and fail on close inspection — so you inspect closely.

The five-point authentication check

Work through these in order. Each takes under a minute, and no single point proves authenticity on its own — but three or more red flags means walk away.

- 1 **Price logic.** If a brand that reliably resells at a certain range is offered far below it, the deal is not a bargain, it is a trap. Scammers price just below the market average so the item sells before anyone notices.
- 2 **The tag and label.** Authentic tags use consistent, legible fonts with correct spelling, barcodes and often a QR code. Replicas show faded print, misspellings, or a font that does not match the brand's own website. Compare the tag to the brand's official product photo.

- 3 **Stitching and seams.** Branded clothing has even stitching, matched thread colour and flat seams. Fakes show loose threads, uneven spacing, puckered fabric or a seam that is slightly the wrong shade. Zoom into listing photos; if the seller refuses close-ups, that is itself a red flag.
- 4 **The logo.** Logos have exact proportions, kerning and weight. Pull the official logo up in another tab and compare letter spacing and alignment. A logo that is slightly bolder, thinner or mis-spaced is a fake.
- 5 **The wash-care label.** The internal care label is the counterfeiter's weak point. Look for typos in the fabric composition, wrong language translations, or symbols that do not match standard textile care marks. A crooked or hastily sewn inner tag is a giveaway.

Brand-by-brand shortcuts that actually work

Some categories have specific tells worth memorising.

- **Activewear (e.g. Lululemon-type pieces):** check the fabric-composition tag against the brand's real fabrics; fakes often read "100% polyester" or use generic names. Check for flatlock (smooth, unpuckered) seams — fakes use overlocked seams that leave a ridge you can feel.
- **Logo-heavy streetwear and sportswear:** the embroidered logo should have dimensional, precise stitching; a flat or printed logo is suspect. Compare spacing on the official site.
- **Designer and bridal wear:** turn the garment inside out first — lining and seam finish expose a replica faster than the front. Real zari and handwork feel heavy and show slight irregularity; plastic metallic thread reflects a harsh glare and machine embroidery looks stiff and flat.
- **Anything with a QR or serial code:** many modern premium brands embed a scannable code. Ask the seller to photograph it, then scan it — a code that leads to a broken or generic page is a fake.

Where to check before you buy

Reverse-image-search the listing photos: if the same shots appear on unrelated pages, the seller likely does not hold the stock. Search the seller's handle or business name plus the word "scam". On marketplaces, prefer verified sellers and brand-registered storefronts. And always ask yourself the question the scammers are betting you will skip: can this seller prove, today, that this exact item is in their hands?

The 15-second rule

Ask for a 15-second video of the item with a handwritten note carrying your name. Scammers working from stolen photos cannot comply. Honest sellers will. This one request filters out the majority of fake listings.

Chapter 7 — Paying safely and the buyer's scam playbook

The single most common thrift scam in India follows the same script every time: the buyer pays in advance to a personal UPI ID or bank account, the seller shares a fake courier tracking number, and then the account goes private or blocks the buyer. Once the money has left your account, it is very hard to get back. Prevention is the whole game.

Red flags — any two of these and you should stop

- Payment is demanded only by direct UPI or bank transfer, and cash-on-delivery, a payment link or any escrow is refused.

- The "store" is only an Instagram handle or WhatsApp number, with no website, no policies and no contact details.
- The account is brand-new, or has reviews that look copied, or product photos you can find on other pages.
- The seller moves the conversation off Instagram to WhatsApp quickly and pushes for fast payment.
- "Only two left, pay in ten minutes" — manufactured urgency designed to stop you checking.
- They cannot or will not send a live video of the item.

Safe ways to pay

- **Cash on delivery (COD)** where offered — you pay the courier when the parcel arrives. Some sellers offer partial COD, which shares the risk.
- **A proper payment gateway link** (Razorpay, PayU, Cashfree and similar) that shows the merchant name and amount, and gives you a receipt and an invoice. This is far safer than a personal UPI transfer.
- **Marketplace checkout** with buyer protection on the organised resale platforms — you get a return window and a dispute route.
- **Escrow-style platforms** where the seller is paid after delivery.

If you are cheated, act in the first 72 hours

Speed is everything, because a fast freeze can catch the money before it is withdrawn. The sequence that works:

- 1 Screenshot everything — the entire chat, the profile, the listing and the payment receipt.
- 2 Call the national cybercrime helpline on **1930** and file a complaint at cybercrime.gov.in, citing cheating under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the relevant IT Act provisions.
- 3 Ask the cyber cell to freeze the beneficiary bank account — this is most likely to succeed within 72 hours.
- 4 Raise a dispute or chargeback with your bank or UPI app (UPI apps such as PhonePe and Paytm have in-app dispute flows).
- 5 File a consumer complaint with the National Consumer Helpline on **1915** or your district consumer commission.
- 6 Report the account to Instagram.

The rule that protects you most

Never send money to a personal UPI ID for a prepaid-only deal from an unverified seller. If a seller will not accept COD, a gateway link or a marketplace checkout, the risk is yours alone — and that is exactly the position a scammer wants you in.

Chapter 8 — The closet audit: what to sell, what to let go

Start by getting honest about your cupboard. The goal is not to sell everything — it is to find the pieces that will actually sell, price them well, and let the rest go without guilt. An hour of sorting typically adds 20-30% to what you realise, because you stop wasting effort on dead stock.

Sort into three piles

Pile	What goes in it	What you do with it
Sell	Branded, in good condition, in demand, clean and complete.	Photograph, list, price on the ladder.
Donate / give away	Worn but wearable basics; anything you would not buy yourself.	NGO, family, or a donation bin.
Recycle / repair	Stained, torn, faded or single items with no pair.	Repair if worth it; otherwise textile recycling.

What sells in India — and what does not

Indian resale has clear favourites. Ethnic and occasion wear — sarees, lehengas, kurtas — is the strongest category, because there is no size risk and festive demand repeats every year. Kidswear bundles move fastest because children outgrow clothes quickly. Branded casual wear, denim, jackets and sneakers sell well when priced honestly. What sits: generic fast-fashion basics, garments with visible damage, and anything a buyer could buy new for close to your asking price.

What your cupboard is actually worth

A rough guide so you can size up your own closet before you start. Percentages are of the item's original retail price.

Category	Typical resale	Why
Sarees & ethnic wear	30-60% of retail	No size risk; festive and wedding demand.
Branded tops & denim	25-40%	Recognised brands carry resale value.
Winter wear & jackets	25-40%	Seasonal; jackets lead thrift searches.
Kidswear bundles	Rs.150-400 per bundle	Outgrown fast; sold in lots.
Shoes (good brands)	20-40%	Condition-dependent; check soles.
Everyday fast fashion	15-30%	Lowest tier; best sold in bundles.

The test for every item

- Would I buy this at my asking price, in this condition, from a stranger?
- Is it clean, pressed and complete (buttons, belts, dupattas, original packaging where relevant)?
- Is it in demand in my city or online right now?
- Do I have measurements, and photos of any flaw?

Do not skip the wash

A clean, pressed, neatly folded garment photographs better, sells faster and commands a higher price. A quick wash, a de-pill and a steam are the cheapest upgrades to your sale price you will ever make.

Chapter 9 — Thrifting by category: what sells in India

Not every category behaves the same way. Knowing what sells in India — and what to check in each — lets you source and price with confidence.

Category	Why it sells	What to check	Price note
Sarees & ethnic wear	No size risk; recurring festive and wedding demand.	Fabric, zari quality, stains, falls/pico done.	Strongest category; holds value.
Kidswear	Children outgrow fast; bundles move quickest.	Stains, worn knees, missing sets.	Sell as bundles.
Denim & streetwear	Young, urban, Y2K and oversized trends.	Fade, stretched knees, original hem.	Mid to premium.
Sneakers & bags	Brand-led demand.	Sole wear, insoles, authenticity.	Authenticate carefully.
Winter wear	Seasonal spikes; jackets lead searches.	Pilling, lining, moth holes.	Buy in summer, sell in winter.
Home & furniture	Relocations and first homes.	Sturdiness, missing fittings, transport cost.	Local-only; avoid shipping.
Books	Cheap, light, evergreen.	Edition, condition, missing pages.	Bundle by subject.

The two categories a beginner should start with

Sarees and ethnic wear are the safest first category: there is no size risk, festive demand repeats every year, and buyers actively seek pre-loved pieces at a fraction of retail. Kidswear bundles are the fastest to clear. Start with one, master the process, then add the next.

Thrift for every body

Three audiences are underserved by thrift sellers, which makes them good niches.

- **Men's wear:** denim, shirts, formal jackets and sneakers are in steady demand and often under-listed. Sourcing is easy because men's cupboards clear just as fast.
- **Plus-size and extended sizes:** buyers in larger sizes struggle to find good pre-loved options, so well-curated pages in these sizes build loyal followings and hold their price.
- **Kidswear:** the fastest-moving category of all — parents buy bundles repeatedly as children grow.

Pick the niche you understand, and be the best page in it rather than a general store.

Follow the search data

Google's India data showed jackets as the most-searched thrift item, with vintage sarees and Y2K streetwear both surging. Match your sourcing to what your city is actually searching for.

Chapter 10 — Pricing your items: the ladder and the maths

Pricing is where most beginners either leave money on the table or sit on stock that never moves. The fix is a consistent ladder, adjusted for brand, condition and demand.

The pricing ladder

Tier	Condition	Typical asking price	Example
Premium / designer	Like new	40-60% of original retail	A Rs.8,000 branded jacket listed at Rs.3,500-4,800
Mid-tier brands	Good to like new	25-40% of retail	A Rs.2,500 kurta set listed at Rs.700-1,000
Everyday / fast fashion	Good	15-30% of retail	A Rs.1,200 top listed at Rs.250-350
Flawed but wearable	Fair	10-25% of retail	Disclosed small stain, priced accordingly

A worked clearout

Here is how the maths lands for a realistic 30-piece clearout. The premium third does the heavy lifting.

Segment	Pieces	Avg price	Subtotal
Premium / branded	10	Rs.850	Rs.8,500
Mid-tier	12	Rs.250	Rs.3,000
Everyday / bundles	8	Rs.80	Rs.640
Total	30		Rs.12,140

Subtract shipping and any platform fee and you can see why self-selling your best pieces beats dumping everything into a bulk lot. A realistic 30-piece clearout realises roughly Rs.12,000, with the premium third producing more than half of it.

Three pricing habits that raise your average

- **Price the bundle, not just the piece.** "Buy 2, get 15% off" and kidswear bundles lift the average order value without discounting your best item.
- **Anchor with "was" pricing.** State the original retail and your price — buyers understand value faster when they can see the gap.
- **Run a timed clearance.** Every few weeks, clear slow stock at a lower price rather than letting it age. Old stock costs you storage and attention.

Chapter 11 — Photography and listings that sell

In resale, the photograph is the product. A well-lit, honest set of photos can double what a piece fetches; a blurry, dark shot leaves money on the table. You can do all of this with one phone.

The five-shot rule

Every listing needs at least these five images. No exceptions.

- 1 **Front** — the full garment, flat or on a hanger, filling the frame.
- 2 **Back** — shows the cut, length and any back flaw.
- 3 **Brand tag** — builds trust and helps authentication.
- 4 **Wash-care label** — the fibre composition buyers want to see.

- 5 **Flaw close-up** — the honest photo that prevents a return.

Light and background do the heavy lifting

- **Shoot in daylight**, near a window, never under a yellow bulb.
- **Use a plain, clean background** — a white wall or a light bedsheet. Clutter steals attention.
- **Hang or flat-lay**; avoid dark, cluttered rooms.
- **Straighten and press first** — creases read as neglect.

The caption that closes the sale

Pair the photos with the listing template (in the template pack) so the buyer gets measurements, condition, price and shipping in one glance. Buyers decide fast; make the decision easy. And post drops at the same announced time each week — consistency is what turns followers into regulars.

One photo tip worth more than a filter

Add a common object — a coin or a hand — beside the item for scale. Buyers judge size poorly from photos alone, and a scale reference cuts size-related messages dramatically.

Chapter 12 — Your Instagram thrift store, step by step

Instagram is where used clothing earns its highest prices in India. The reason is curation: a page that shows a clear taste and an honest process is worth more to a buyer than an anonymous listing. Here is how to build one.

Set-up, in one evening

- 1 Create a **business account** — it gives you order, follower and engagement analytics a personal account lacks.
- 2 Write a one-line bio that names your niche ("Y2K streetwear, sizes S-M, ships pan-India") and your process ("claim in DM -> pay by UPI -> ships twice a week").
- 3 Pin a post that explains how to buy from you, so first-time visitors are not confused.
- 4 Set up a simple payment method — a UPI ID or, better, a payment-gateway link that shows your business name and a receipt.
- 5 Save highlights for reviews, customer photos and past drops.

How a drop works

A drop is a timed release of curated pieces. The format Indian buyers already expect:

- 1 Announce the drop 4-5 days ahead with stories and a sneak peek, so followers show up on time.
- 2 Post the pieces as a numbered carousel or stories, each with measurements in centimetres, the condition grade and the price.
- 3 Buyers claim first-come in DMs. Confirm the item, then take payment by UPI before dispatch.
- 4 Ship in a batch — twice a week is the standard rhythm — and share the tracking number immediately.

The five practices that separate pages that grow

- **A consistent niche.** Y2K, oversized streetwear, sarees, kidswear — pick one and own it.
- **Measurements in every caption.** Chest, length, shoulder, waist. This is what serious buyers want.
- **Announced drop times.** Consistency builds the habit that makes followers return.
- **Visible proof.** Story highlights of customer photos and reviews turn one-time buyers into repeat ones.
- **Neat packaging.** A poly bag, a thank-you note and a final flaw recheck before dispatch cost little and earn loyalty.

A four-week content plan

Consistency is what grows a page. Here is a simple monthly rhythm you can repeat.

Week	Focus	What to post
1	Announce & drop	Sneak peek, then the numbered drop; claims in DMs.
2	Proof & restock	Buyer photo reviews in stories; a small mid-week restock.
3	Themed drop	A curated niche drop (Y2K, sarees, kidswear) to attract that audience.
4	Clearance	Discount slow stock; a "buy 2 get 15% off" offer.

Post stories daily, even when there is no drop — a tip, a styling idea, a behind-the-scenes packing clip. Stories keep you visible in the algorithm and keep your audience warm between drops.

Payments and pricing discipline

Take the payment first, then ship — always. The safest option is a payment-gateway link that confirms instantly on your dashboard, so you never rely on a screenshot that could be edited. If you accept UPI directly, verify the money has actually landed in your bank account, not just that a "payment done" screen was shared. Build a simple one-page policy: no returns on disclosed-condition items, a refund or exchange if the item materially differs from the listing, and unboxing-video evidence required for damage claims.

From cupboard to business

A page with 5,000-15,000 engaged followers routinely clears 30-80 pieces per drop. That is a real business built on a phone — and it starts with one honest drop of ten or twelve pieces.

Chapter 13 — Marketplaces compared: apps, platforms, classifieds

You do not have to choose between Instagram and apps. Most sellers split their stock: the best pieces self-sold on Instagram for the highest price, the bulk cleared through an app for convenience. This table maps the options.

Channel	Model	Best for	Cost to seller
Instagram thrift page	Own-brand social selling	Curated, vintage, higher-priced pieces	Free + your time
Pickup apps (e.g. FreeUp, Tooused)	Doorstep or bulk pickup	Clearing a full wardrobe fast	Commission or per-lot pricing

Channel	Model	Best for	Cost to seller
Thrift marketplaces (e.g. Rewago, Closeit, Presquo, WishThrift, ThriftedRack, Slayyitt)	Searchable storefront, some with COD	Reaching buyers beyond your followers	Varies: some free, some commission
Full-service resale (e.g. Threadko)	They pick up, price, list and pay out	Sellers who want zero logistics	Per-item prep fee (e.g. about Rs.75/item)
Classifieds (OLX, Quikr, Facebook Marketplace)	Local meet-ups	Bulk lots, furniture, local-only items	Free

How to choose, in one line each

- **Want the highest price per piece?** Sell yourself on Instagram.
- **Want the least effort?** Use a pickup app or a full-service resale platform.
- **Want buyers outside your followers?** List on a thrift marketplace with its own traffic.
- **Want speed and no fees?** Clear bulk locally through classifieds.

Watch the fees, not just the headline

A "free listing" platform can still charge on sale, or on shipping, or take a per-item prep fee. Before you commit a batch, ask three questions: what does it cost me per item sold, who pays return shipping, and when do I get paid? Threadko, for example, charges a small per-item prep fee and pays out by UPI after the item sells — which is fine if you value the convenience, and expensive if you do not. Read the current fee page before you list, because these numbers change.

The split-stock strategy

Send your best ten pieces to Instagram, your everyday wear to an app, and your true bulk to a classifieds lot. This single decision maximises both your price and your free time.

Chapter 14 — Shipping and payments in India

Two practical systems decide whether reselling is profitable or a headache: how you ship, and how you get paid. Get both right and each parcel is a two-minute job.

Shipping: the cheapest reliable options

India Post's Speed Post is the cheapest direct network for most small parcels and reaches almost every PIN code. The official retail tariff (effective 1 August 2026) is weight- and distance-based. Indicative rates, before 18% GST:

Weight	Local	Within state	Metro / zone	Other states
Up to 500 g	Rs.28	Rs.76	Rs.82	Rs.90
501-1000 g	Rs.48	Rs.101	Rs.137	Rs.143
1001-1500 g	Rs.60	Rs.130	Rs.182	Rs.228

Source: India Post Speed Post Parcel domestic retail tariff, effective 01.08.2026. Rates exclude GST (about 18%) and are revised periodically — confirm on the India Post calculator before booking.

For regular sellers, shipping aggregators such as Shiprocket and NimbusPost pool thousands of sellers' volumes and negotiate enterprise rates, with entry prices from roughly Rs.20-26 per 500 grams across many courier partners. Contractual India Post rates are also lower than retail. The rule is simple: aggregators win on urban volume, India Post wins on rural reach, and you should match the channel to each parcel.

Packaging that survives the journey

- Use a poly bag or a lightweight box, taped securely — apparel is light, so postage stays in the cheapest slabs.
- Fold neatly; add a thank-you note and a final flaw recheck before sealing.
- Include the buyer's name and PIN code exactly as given, and share the tracking number the moment you book.

Payments: collect before you ship

The peer-to-peer rule is non-negotiable: payment before dispatch, tracking shared immediately after. Your options, in order of safety for the seller:

- 1 **Payment-gateway link** (Razorpay, PayU, Cashfree and similar) — instant confirmation on your dashboard, a receipt for the buyer, and no reliance on screenshots.
- 2 **UPI to your account** — fine for small amounts, but verify the money has actually landed in your bank account, not just a "paid" screen.
- 3 **COD via courier** — convenient for the buyer, but you carry return risk and pay COD handling fees, so use it selectively.

Screenshot fraud is real

A "payment done" screenshot can be edited in seconds. Never treat a screenshot as proof of payment — confirm the credit in your own bank or app, or use a gateway link that confirms automatically. This one habit prevents the most common seller loss.

Chapter 15 — Seller scams, returns and disputes

Sellers get scammed too, and the losses are quieter than a buyer's but just as real. Here is what to watch for, and how to protect your side of the transaction.

The scams aimed at sellers

Scam	How it works	How to stop it
Fake payment screenshot	Buyer sends an edited "payment successful" image and asks you to ship.	Confirm the credit in your own account; use a gateway link.
Overpayment / refund trick	Buyer "accidentally" pays extra, then asks you to refund the difference to a different account.	Refund only the exact original payment to the original source.
Return-to-empty / item swap	Buyer claims a different or damaged item arrived and demands a refund.	Require an unboxing video for damage claims; photograph the packed parcel.
Address-change after payment	After paying, the buyer asks you to ship to a new address.	Ship only to the address confirmed at payment.
Chargeback abuse	Buyer pays, receives the item, then disputes the card payment.	Keep the tracking proof, delivery confirmation and chat records.

A one-page policy that ends most arguments

Publish this in your bio or a pinned post. It protects you and reassures honest buyers:

- No returns on items whose condition and flaws were disclosed in the listing.
- A refund or exchange if the item materially differs from the listing (wrong item, undisclosed damage).
- Damage claims require an unboxing video, sent within 24 hours of delivery.
- Payment is collected before dispatch; tracking is shared on booking.
- Clear communication for any delay — a message prevents a dispute.

Record-keeping is your defence

Keep the listing, the chat, the payment record, the tracking number and the delivery confirmation for every order. If a dispute escalates to a platform or a bank, those five items are what win it.

Chapter 16 — The reselling model: sourcing, margins, the maths

Selling your own cupboard is decluttering. Buying to resell is a business. The moment you buy an item specifically to sell it, you have a different tax and record-keeping situation (Chapter 18) — and a different opportunity.

Where to source cheaply

- **Thrift stores and flea markets:** the classic entry point. Buy low in bulk, curate, re-sell higher.
- **Bulk lots and clearance:** brands, exporters and closing shops sell unsold or sample stock in lots — good for volume, but inspect for flaws.
- **Wardrobe buys:** offer to clear a friend's or a neighbour's cupboard for a flat price, then sort and resell.
- **Seasonal timing:** buy winter wear in summer and festive/ethnic wear just after a festival, when prices are lowest.

How to buy a bulk lot without getting burned

Bulk lots are how resellers scale, but a bad lot can wipe out a month of profit. Ask these before you pay.

- What is the category mix, and roughly how many pieces?
- What share of the lot is flawed, and can I see a photo of the actual lot — not a stock image?
- Is the price per piece, per kilogram, or for the whole lot?
- What happens if a large share is unsellable — is there any return or adjustment?
- Can I start with a small test lot before committing to a large one?

The golden rule: know your target cost per piece before you buy, and walk away if the lot cannot beat it after cleaning, shipping and fees.

The margin maths, worked honestly

Reselling is a thin-margin game; the profit is in sourcing and in time. Here is a realistic single-item example and a monthly picture.

Line	Single item example	Monthly example (40 items)
Sourcing cost	Rs.150	Rs.6,000
Cleaning / prep	Rs.20	Rs.800
Shipping (avg)	Rs.70	Rs.2,800
Selling price	Rs.450	Rs.18,000
Gross profit	Rs.210	Rs.8,400

Illustrative figures only. Your numbers depend on your sourcing, your city and your niche.

What makes the difference between profit and a hobby

- 1 **Source cheap.** Your margin is decided the day you buy, not the day you sell.
- 2 **Curate hard.** One in-demand piece earns more than five that sit. Skip anything you would not buy yourself.
- 3 **Price on the ladder.** Use Chapter 10 so you neither undersell nor sit on stock.
- 4 **Keep time down.** Batch your photography, listing and shipping; unbatched work is what kills the hourly rate.
- 5 **Track every rupee.** A simple sheet for cost, price and fees tells you which category actually earns.

The honest expectation

Most beginners earn a few thousand rupees a month within 90 days, not a full salary. The ones who grow treat it like a small shop: consistent sourcing, honest grading, fast shipping and clean books. Do that and the numbers compound.

Chapter 17 — Scaling up and the 90-day plan

Once the basics work, growth comes from three levers: more and better stock, a bigger and more loyal audience, and lower cost per parcel. Here is a plan you can actually run.

The 90-day plan

Phase	Focus	Goal by the end of the phase
Days 1-30	Sell your own cupboard; set up Instagram; learn pricing and shipping.	First Rs.3,000-5,000 earned; process mastered.
Days 31-60	Start sourcing to resell; run weekly drops; build reviews.	Consistent weekly sales; a repeat-buyer list.
Days 61-90	Widen sourcing; add a marketplace for reach; sharpen your niche.	Rs.10,000+ in monthly sales; clean records for tax.

The three growth levers

- **Better stock beats more stock.** Move up the ladder — one premium piece at 40-60% of retail earns more than five fast-fashion tops.
- **Turn buyers into followers into repeat buyers.** Ask for a photo review after delivery; feature it in a highlight; a loyal circle is cheaper than ads.
- **Cut your cost per parcel.** Once you ship regularly, move to an aggregator or a contractual India Post rate and save on every order.

When to slow down

If stock is not moving, the problem is almost always price or photography, not the market. Re-shoot in daylight, re-write the caption with measurements, and re-price on the ladder before you buy more. Adding stock to a system that is not converting just adds clutter.

The one metric that matters early

Track your sell-through rate: the share of listed items that sell within 30 days. If it is under half, fix pricing and photos before you scale. If it is high, buy more of what sold.

Chapter 18 — GST and income tax for resellers

This is the chapter people skip and later regret. The good news: most people selling their own used clothes owe nothing. The rules change the moment you buy to resell. Here is the clear picture, and when to call an accountant.

Personal decluttering is not a business

Selling clothes you already owned and wore — occasional personal decluttering — is not a taxable business activity in the ordinary case. The line is crossed when you buy goods specifically to resell, systematically, for profit. That is a business, and it brings GST and income-tax questions with it.

GST: the margin scheme rewards honest resellers

GST applies to second-hand goods like any other supply, but a special relief exists for dealers in used goods. Under the **Margin Scheme** (Rule 32(5) of the CGST Rules), a registered dealer who buys and sells second-hand goods — as they are, or after minor processing that does not change their nature — and who does not claim input tax credit (ITC) on the purchase, pays GST only on the margin: the difference between the selling price and the purchase price. If there is no margin, no GST is payable. Purchases from unregistered suppliers are exempt (Notification 10/2017), so the purchase leg does not attract reverse-charge GST in this case.

Two registration points to know

- **Selling through your own Instagram or website:** normal threshold rules apply — registration becomes mandatory once aggregate turnover crosses Rs.40 lakh for goods in most states, or immediately if you make inter-state supplies.
- **Selling through an e-commerce operator:** registration is generally compulsory regardless of turnover under Section 24(ix) of the CGST Act, with one narrow relief (Notification 34/2023) for small goods sellers who sell only within one state, below the threshold, with a PAN and an enrolment number. The rules here are evolving — the GST Council has been simplifying them for small sellers — so confirm the current position before you onboard.

Income tax: presumptive taxation keeps it simple

If your reselling is a business, you can often use **presumptive taxation**. Under the old Section 44AD — now Section 58 of the Income-tax Act, 2025 for tax year 2026-27 onward — an eligible resident individual, HUF or firm can declare profit at 6% of turnover received through banking or digital modes (8% for cash receipts), for turnover up to Rs.2 crore (Rs.3 crore where cash receipts are 5% or less). This spares you from maintaining detailed books and an audit, as long as you declare at those rates.

A worked example

Say you resell clothes and, in tax year 2026-27, your total turnover is Rs.4,00,000, all received by UPI. Under presumptive taxation you may declare profit at 6% of that turnover — Rs.24,000 — as your business income, without maintaining detailed books or getting an audit. If part of your turnover was received in cash, that portion is declared at 8% instead. You can always declare a higher, actual profit if you prefer. The point is simplicity: a small reseller can stay compliant with a single, easy-to-calculate figure.

Platform TDS and TCS

Selling through a marketplace, you may see two deductions. GST **TCS** under Section 52 is collected by the platform at 0.5%. Income-tax **TDS** on e-commerce sales (formerly Section 194-O, now in the Income-tax Act, 2025) is deducted at 0.1%, with the first Rs.5 lakh of gross sales exempt for a resident individual or HUF who has furnished PAN or Aadhaar to the platform. Reconcile both every month against your own sales register.

The three records to keep from day one

1) Every purchase (date, item, cost). 2) Every sale (date, item, price, fee). 3) Every platform statement and bank credit. A one-sheet log of these three is enough to answer most tax questions — and to let an accountant file for you quickly. For anything material, confirm with a chartered accountant, because GST and income-tax rules depend on your exact situation.

Chapter 19 — The consumer rules and policies you must publish

The moment you sell to consumers online, the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020 apply to how you present your goods and handle problems. You do not need a law degree — you need clear policies and honest listings.

What the rules expect of a seller

- Display the total price in a single figure, with a clear break-up of any compulsory and voluntary charges (including delivery).
- Describe the goods accurately — description, images and features must match what you actually ship.
- Do not refuse to take back or refund goods that are defective, spurious or not as advertised, or that arrive late.
- State your terms for exchange, returns and refunds, including who bears return-shipping cost, in a clear and accessible way.
- Provide a grievance contact and resolve complaints promptly.

The policies to publish on your page

Put these where a buyer can see them — a pinned post, a highlight or a simple link. They double as your protection.

- 1 **Return & refund policy:** when you accept returns and when you do not, and the timeline.
- 2 **Shipping policy:** courier used, dispatch days, and expected delivery time.
- 3 **Payment policy:** methods accepted, and the rule that payment precedes dispatch.
- 4 **Contact details:** how a buyer reaches you for a problem.

Honesty is the cheapest marketing

Accurate listings and published policies reduce disputes, build reviews and let you charge a little more. In a market where trust is scarce, the seller who is easy to verify wins the repeat buyer every time.

Chapter 20 — Sustainability: why this matters

The environmental case for thrift is not a slogan — it is arithmetic. India generates roughly 70.73 lakh tonnes of textile waste a year, more than half of it post-consumer clothing. Of that waste, a large share still goes to incineration or landfill. Every garment that is re-worn instead of discarded keeps fabric, water and carbon in circulation and out of waste.

The numbers behind the habit

- Extending a garment's life by even a few months sharply cuts its carbon, water and waste impact compared with buying new.
- More than 70% of India's textile waste is already recovered into reuse and recycling streams — thrift is the front end of that system.
- India's textile recycling market is projected to reach USD 3.5 billion by 2030, with about one lakh new green jobs.
- The collection, sorting and redistribution of used textiles already sustains roughly 40-45 lakh livelihoods, mostly women.

Your part in it

Every resale is a small environmental act and a small economic one. When you sell a garment, you keep it in use and put money back in your pocket. When you buy pre-loved, you avoid the footprint of a new one and often get better quality for less. And when you build a reselling business, you are creating value from what was already there — the most sustainable model there is.

How to donate and recycle responsibly

Not every garment should be sold. Get the last mile right and your decluttering does real good.

- **Donate what is wearable.** Well-known Indian organisations such as Goonj channel usable clothing to people who need it — donate clean, folded, wearable garments, not rags.
- **Recycle what is worn out.** Torn, stained or single items belong in textile recycling, not a donation bin. Many cities now run textile collection alongside dry-waste drives.
- **Sell what has value.** Branded, good-condition pieces earn you cash and keep the item in use — the most circular outcome of all.
- **Never bin wearable clothes.** A garment in the bin is a garment in landfill; the same garment donated or sold keeps working.

The circular loop

Buy well -> wear often -> sell or give on -> someone else wears it -> eventually recycle. Thrift is not a detour from the loop; it is the loop working as it should.

Chapter 21 — Common mistakes that cost you money

These are the errors that separate a profitable thrift habit from an expensive one. Read this list before your first sale and again after your tenth.

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
Buying without measurements	Returns, disputes, dead stock.	Get measurements in cm before paying.
Ignoring shipping in pricing	You sell at a loss on light items.	Price with postage built in.
Trusting a payment screenshot	Losing the item and the money.	Confirm the credit or use a gateway link.
Not disclosing a flaw	Returns, bad reviews, lost buyers.	Photograph and describe every flaw.
Overpricing to "leave room"	Stock that never sells.	Price on the ladder from Chapter 10.

Mistake	What it costs	The fix
Underpricing premium pieces	Leaving money on the table.	Price the top tier at 40-60% of retail.
No records	Tax stress and missed profit.	Log purchases, sales and fees from day one.
Slow shipping	Lost trust, fewer repeats.	Ship in fixed weekly batches, tracking shared at once.

The one habit that prevents most of these

Write the listing as if you were the buyer. If you would not pay your own asking price, in that condition, with those photos — fix the listing before you publish it.

Chapter 22 — Frequently asked questions

Is buying second-hand online in India safe?

It can be, if you verify the seller and pay safely. Prefer marketplaces with buyer protection, insist on COD or a gateway link over a personal UPI transfer, and ask for a live video before a prepaid high-value purchase.

Do I need GST to sell my own old clothes?

Selling clothes you already owned and wore — occasional personal decluttering — is not ordinarily a taxable business. GST questions begin when you buy goods specifically to resell, systematically, for profit.

How much can I realistically earn?

Most beginners earn a few thousand rupees a month within 90 days. A realistic 30-piece clearout of your own wardrobe can realise roughly Rs.12,000 before shipping and fees. Systematic resellers earn more by sourcing and curating.

Which platform should I start with?

Sell your own cupboard on Instagram for the best price per piece, and use a pickup app or marketplace if you want less effort. Buy from channels with buyer protection until you know a seller.

How do I price a used garment?

Use the pricing ladder: premium/designer like-new at 40-60% of retail, mid-tier at 25-40%, everyday at 15-30%, and flawed items lower still. Adjust for demand and condition.

What if the buyer does not pay or disappears?

Reserve items only briefly. If payment does not arrive, release the item to the next claimant. Always collect payment before dispatch.

Am I legally required to accept returns?

Under the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020 you must take back or refund goods that are defective, spurious or not as advertised. For disclosed-condition items, state your policy clearly in advance.

Is it legal to resell branded clothes?

Reselling genuine, previously owned branded garments is normal. Selling counterfeit goods as genuine is fraud — which is exactly why authentication (Chapter 6) matters.

How do I ship cheaply?

India Post Speed Post is the cheapest direct option for most small parcels and reaches nearly every PIN code; shipping aggregators offer low urban rates for regular sellers. Match the channel to the parcel.

Do I need a business name or registration to start?

Not to sell your own clothes. If you scale into buying-to-resell, consider a simple business name, a Udyam/MSME registration for credibility, and a current account for clean records.

What if I am scammed as a buyer?

Act within 72 hours: screenshot everything, call 1930, file at cybercrime.gov.in, ask your bank to freeze the beneficiary account, raise a UPI/card dispute, and file a consumer complaint on 1915.

Is thrifting really worth the effort?

For buyers, it means good clothes for less. For sellers, it means cash from a cupboard plus a low-investment side income. The system in this book is what makes the effort pay off.

Reference & quick-start

The material you will come back to again and again: how to measure, where to thrift in person, a seven-day plan, and every verified number in this book in one place.

Measuring and sizing: the reference you'll keep

Brand labels lie; tape measures do not. Learn to measure a garment flat and you can buy with confidence from any seller, anywhere.

How to measure a garment flat (in centimetres)

- **Chest / bust:** lay the top flat, measure across from one underarm seam to the other, then double it.
- **Waist:** measure across the narrowest point of the garment flat, then double it.
- **Length:** from the highest point of the shoulder (or the neckline) straight down to the hem.
- **Shoulder:** across the back, from one shoulder seam to the other.
- **Inseam:** for trousers, from the crotch seam down to the hem.

Indicative women's size conversion

India	UK	US	EU	Approx. bust (cm)
XS	6	2	34	78-82
S	8	4	36	82-86
M	10	6	38	86-90
L	12	8	40	90-95
XL	14	10	42	95-100

Indicative only — brands differ. Always prefer the seller's flat measurements in centimetres over any letter size.

Offline thrifting: finding and working a real market

A Saturday in the real world will teach you more about prices than a week online. Here is how to work an offline market well.

Where to look

- **Search maps for "thrift store", "second hand clothes" or "flea market"** near you — most metros now have a handful of dedicated thrift shops.
- **Weekly flea markets and Sunday bazaars** — the cheapest stock, but arrive early for the best pieces.
- **NGO and church sales, college "thrift flea" pop-ups and society garage sales** — low prices, good quality, community trust.
- **Exhibition grounds and monthly craft bazaars** — strong for ethnic wear and vintage.

What to bring and how to behave

- Carry cash (small notes) and a UPI app; many stalls take one or the other, rarely both.
- Bring a tape measure and a tote bag — you will want to check measurements and carry finds.
- Inspect before you buy: hold to the light, check seams and underarms, smell the fabric.

- Be a good citizen of the market: do not haggle a fair price to the bone, and do not leave a stall in a mess.

Best days and timing

Mornings are best — stock is fresh and sellers are in a bargaining mood. Sundays and the days after major festivals see the most stock and the busiest crowds. Winter is the season for jackets and woollens; just after a festival is the time for discounted ethnic wear.

Your first 7 days

A simple, concrete start. Do not skip ahead.

Day	Action
1	Audit your cupboard into Sell / Donate / Recycle. Pick 10-12 sellable pieces.
2	Wash, press and photograph the best pieces using the five-shot rule (Chapter 11).
3	Set up your Instagram business account, write the bio and pin the how-to-buy post.
4	Price every piece on the ladder (Chapter 10) and write captions with measurements.
5	Announce your first drop and take claims in DMs; collect payment before dispatch.
6	Ship the batch, share tracking, and note your costs and prices in a simple sheet.
7	Review what sold, ask two buyers for a photo review, and plan your next drop.

Quick reference: the verified numbers in this book

Fact	Figure	Source
India textile waste per year	~70.73 lakh tonnes	Ministry of Textiles, Mar 2026
Share that is post-consumer	58%	Ministry of Textiles, Mar 2026
India second-hand apparel market	USD 3.0B (2023) to USD 9.1B (2032)	Credence Research
Rise in "how to thrift" searches	+850% in a year	Google India, Oct 2026
Rise in "circular fashion" searches	+2,500% in a year	Google India, Oct 2026
GST Margin Scheme	Tax on the margin only (Rule 32(5))	CBIC / GST Council
Presumptive business tax	6% digital / 8% cash, up to Rs.2-3 cr	Income-tax Act, 2025, s.58
Marketplace GST TCS	0.5% (Sec 52)	CGST Act
Marketplace income-tax TDS	0.1%, Rs.5 lakh exemption for individuals	Income-tax Act, 2025
India Post Speed Post (500g, local)	Rs.28 (excl. GST)	India Post, effective 01.08.2026
Shipping aggregator entry rate	from ~Rs.20-26 per 500g	Shiprocket / NimbusPost

Figures verified in October 2026 and subject to change — confirm current rates before a large transaction.

Template pack — copy these into your phone

Five ready-to-use tools. Adapt the wording to your own voice.

1. Listing template

Copy this structure for every listing

[Item] — [Brand] — Size [letter]

Measurements (cm): Chest ___ · Length ___ · Shoulder ___ · Waist ___

Condition: [NWT / Like new / Good / Fair] — [flaws, if any]

Colour: ___ · Fabric: ___

Price: Rs. ___ (original retail Rs. ___)

Ships in [x] days via [courier]. Payment before dispatch.

Photos: front · back · tag · wash-care label · any flaw

2. Pricing sheet

Item	Brand	Condition	Retail	Ask (ladder %)	Final price

3. Inventory tracker

Date listed	Item	Cost	Listed price	Sold?	Fee	Net

4. DM scripts

- **Buyer enquiry:** "Hi! Sending the details for [item]: measurements, condition, price and shipping — all below. Happy to send a quick video too."
- **Confirming an order:** "Reserved for you. Here is the secure payment link for Rs. ___ — your order ships within 24 hours of payment. Thank you!"
- **After delivery:** "Hope you love it! If you are happy, a quick photo review would mean a lot — it helps other buyers trust the page."
- **Handling a problem:** "Sorry about this — please share an unboxing video and I will sort a refund or replacement right away."

5. Drop checklist

- Announce the drop 4-5 days ahead with a sneak peek.
- Photograph in daylight; include measurements, grade and flaw photos.
- Post the numbered carousel at the announced time.
- Claim, confirm, take payment, then ship in the batch.
- Share tracking immediately; follow up for reviews.

Glossary

NWT — New with tags — unused, original tags attached.

Condition grade — The stated wear level of an item (NWT, like new, good, fair).

Drop — A timed release of curated items, announced in advance, claimed in DMs.

Margin Scheme — The GST rule (Rule 32(5)) that taxes only the profit on second-hand goods.

ITC — Input tax credit — GST paid on purchases, claimable against GST on sales. Not used under the Margin Scheme.

Presumptive taxation — Declaring business profit at a fixed percentage of turnover (Section 58 of the Income-tax Act, 2025).

TCS — Tax collected at source by a marketplace, at 0.5% for goods under Section 52.

COD — Cash on delivery — the buyer pays the courier on arrival.

ASBA / escrow — A payment mechanism where funds are released only after the buyer confirms delivery.

Circular fashion — A system where garments are reused, resold and recycled to keep them in use.

Final word

India's thrift market is at the point where the tools finally match the demand. The supply is real — lakhs of tonnes of clothing a year. The demand is real — a young, online, value-conscious generation that treats pre-loved as a choice, not a compromise. What has been missing is a clear, honest system for the people in the middle: the buyer who wants to pay less and not get scammed, and the seller who wants to earn from a cupboard without losing money to fraud or fines.

That system is now in your hands. Start small: one drop of ten pieces, priced on the ladder, described honestly, shipped on time. Buy with measurements and a 15-second video, and pay through a gateway or COD. Keep three simple records. Do that for ninety days and you will have earned money, learned a market, and built something real from what was already there.

The best time to start thrifting was when the closet filled up. The second-best time is today.